Exhibition Text and Promotional Material

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Introduction

Theft *(noun)*: *an unlawful taking (as by embezzlement or burglary) of property.*
–Merriam-Webster

To most people, theft is intuitive. A pickpocket on a crowded bus, a break-in at an empty home: in both, the culprit is obvious, the victim clear and the law unambiguous.

Yet every word in that definition gives way under pressure. Who is the thief, when one shoplifter is excused as unwell and another is charged, or when looted objects pass through so many hands that no one seems responsible? What counts as property, when an Amazonian seed is grown across an empire, blood given for one study answers another, or a public photograph becomes biometric data?

And what counts as unlawful, when the state's own records call reservation land 'surplus' and an ancestral forest a set of 'coal blocks'? Behind every case sits one more question: who writes the official story, and who is left out of it?

This exhibition looks beyond the pickpocket at how ownership itself is defined. It moves through three questions: who is the thief, what can be taken, and who names the act. As the lines between taker, victim and record-keeper blur, one question remains: has your definition of theft already begun to shift?

Section 1: Who Is the Thief?

Most people can picture a thief: someone who takes what belongs to another, without permission. The thief is usually the easiest person in the story to identify. The label seems to follow from the act. This section tests that idea through four cases.

Each case is checked against three conditions: an owner, a loss, and a law that names the taking as a crime. In an ordinary theft, all three are present, and so is the thief. Each case that follows keeps the taking in plain sight and changes something else.

Two women take the same goods from the same counter, but only one is called a thief. An outlaw robs travellers at knifepoint, and centuries of retelling turn him into a hero. A palace is

looted, and its treasures pass through so many lawful hands that no single person seems to have taken them.

The taking stays visible throughout. What changes is who the taker is, who the victim is, where the goods end up, and how much time has passed. The label ‘thief’ turns out to depend on more than the act.

1. Ordinary Theft

A wallet, taken on a crowded street · Present day

On a crowded street, a hand slips into a pocket and leaves with a wallet. The owner notices only later. A complaint is filed, and if the pickpocket is caught, the law takes its course. Cash, cards and jewellery are taken the same way.

In India, that law is Section 303 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023. It defines theft as dishonestly taking someone’s movable property out of their possession, without consent. The pickpocket’s act fits every part of that definition.

Owner, loss, law: all three are present, and the thief is obvious. Note the word movable. Under this section, land cannot be stolen at all — a limit Section 3 of this exhibition returns to.

2. Kleptomania and Class

Two shoplifters, one counter, two verdicts · Department stores in the United States and Britain, 1870s–1900s

From the 1870s, large department stores spread through American and British cities. Goods sat on open counters, and shoppers could handle them freely. Shoplifting rose with them. Many of those caught were middle-class women, the stores’ best customers, taking things they could easily afford. Doctors offered an explanation. Since the early nineteenth century, they had described ‘kleptomania’, an urge to steal. Applied to these women, it turned a crime into an illness. Stores, unwilling to lose respectable customers, often settled such cases quietly.

The diagnosis did not reach everyone. In New York in 1882, Ellen Sardy was caught in a Sixth Avenue department store with three pairs of hosiery and five pieces of silk. Her lawyer admitted the theft and asked for clemency because she had been ‘of weak mind’. The court accepted it and she went free. Historian Elaine Abelson, who recovered the case, writes that only middle-class women seemed to suffer from kleptomania: ‘stealing by members of other classes was simple theft’.

Owner and loss are identical in both cases, and so is the law. Only the person differs. The act did not decide the label; class did.

3. Robbing the Rich

Robin Hood and six centuries of retelling · England, 1370s to today

Robin Hood is first mentioned in the 1370s, when the poem *Piers Plowman* refers to ‘rhymes of Robin Hood’. The poem says nothing about who he was or what he did; it tells us only that such rhymes already circulated.

The earliest surviving ballads, from about 1450, describe an outlaw living in the forest with a band of followers, in conflict with a corrupt sheriff. He stops wealthy travellers on the road and takes what they carry at the point of a weapon. The ballads are frank about the violence, and they are also frank about what they do not say: they do not describe him giving to the poor. That line is first set down plainly by John Stow in 1592, roughly a century after the *Gest*, and it is the version that has lasted.

Owner, loss and law are all present. The travellers owned what they carried, they lost it, and Robin lived outside the law’s protection as a declared outlaw. Nothing is missing. What changed was not the robbery but the story told about it afterwards — and each retelling gave the robberies a better reason.

4. The Benin Bronzes

Who exactly is the thief? · Benin City (now in Nigeria), 1897 to today

In 1897, a British punitive expedition captured Benin City, burned the royal palace and removed thousands of brass plaques, ivories and commemorative heads. Many were auctioned in London to defray the cost of the expedition itself. Others entered Western museums over the following decades through purchase, donation and transfer. These were not currency or raw material: the plaques were the palace’s own record of its dynasty, an archive kept in place.

Owner and loss are not in doubt. What is missing is the third condition. Each transfer was lawful where it took place, and every person in the chain can point to someone earlier. With no act the law named as a crime, the chain has no obvious thief — only a sequence of people who each acted correctly, and a benefit that passed down the line with the objects.

The question has since moved from who took the objects to who holds them now. In 2022 the Smithsonian transferred ownership of 29 objects to Nigeria’s National Commission for Museums and Monuments. In 2023 Nigeria’s outgoing president declared the Oba of Benin the owner of returned bronzes, and who should hold, keep and display them within Nigeria remains disputed. Returning an object settles ownership. It does not settle who is answerable for how it left.

Exhibit Labels and Provenance: Section 1

1. Ordinary Theft

Wallet, cash, cards and jewellery

Present day · Props

Everyday objects of the kind taken in street theft. They are here to fix the familiar case in mind before the rest of the exhibition takes it apart.

Section 303, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita

2023 · Printed extract · Government of India

India's criminal code defines theft as dishonestly taking movable property from someone's possession without consent. Movable is the key word: under this section, land cannot be stolen.

2. Kleptomania and Class

Two shoplifters (film)

Made for this exhibition · Reconstruction

Two women take the same item from the same counter, and the verdicts differ. No footage of the original cases survives, so this scene was staged by the exhibition team.

'Kleptomania', The Journal of Mental Science

July 1862 · British psychiatric journal · Reproduction

A British medical journal describing kleptomania as a disorder of the mind. Writing like this gave families and courts a medical account of shoplifting to set against a criminal one.

3. Robbing the Rich

Robin Hood and the Monk

About 1450 · Ballad extract · Reproduction; original in Cambridge University Library

The oldest surviving Robin Hood ballad, and an openly violent one: Robin is betrayed and captured, and his men kill the monk who informed on him.

A Gest of Robyn Hode

Printed in the early 1500s · Ballad extract · Reproduction

The longest early ballad, stringing several adventures together. Robin helps a poor knight with a loan, but the ballad never says he robbed the rich to give to the poor.

John Stow, The Annales of England

1592 · Extract · Reproduction

The first known text to say plainly that Robin Hood robbed the rich to help the poor, about a century after the Gest. The best-known part of the story is the latest addition.

Robin Hood on screen

1922 and 1938 · Film posters · Reproductions

Posters for the Douglas Fairbanks (1922) and Errol Flynn (1938) films. In both, Robin is a wronged nobleman fighting injustice rather than an outlaw robbing travellers at knifepoint.

4. The Benin Bronzes

Brass plaque from the royal palace of Benin (Image)

16th–17th century · Enlarged image· Original held in a museum collection

Cast by Benin's royal guild of brass casters and fixed to the palace's pillars, plaques like this recorded kings, warriors and court ceremonies. They were the palace's archive, not decoration.

From Benin City to the world (map)

Made for this exhibition · Based on museums' published records

Where objects taken in 1897 are held today, traced through museums' own published records. More than a century later, most of them are still outside Nigeria.

Returning the bronzes

2022–2023 · News reports · Reproductions

Reports on the Smithsonian's transfer of 29 objects to Nigeria's National Commission for Museums and Monuments in October 2022, and on the dispute since, over who within Nigeria should hold and display them.

Section 2: What Can Be Taken?

Three cases, from 1876 to today

Most theft is easy to recognise. Something leaves its owner without permission, and the owner no longer has it. The three cases here are harder. In each, something small moved: seeds from a forest, blood from a village, photos from the internet. Yet it is hard to say what the owner lost. Brazil kept its rubber trees. The donors gave their blood willingly. The original photos stayed online.

What changed was what each thing became: plantations on another continent, data for studies the donors say they never agreed to, a search engine for faces. Those who call these cases theft point to what the thing became, not only to what moved.

The cases span 150 years, from the age of empire to the age of the internet. Each panel sets out what happened, who calls it theft and why, and how the other side answers.

1. Seventy Thousand Seeds

Henry Wickham · the Amazon to Kew Gardens, London · 1876

In 1876, Henry Wickham, an Englishman living in the Amazon, shipped about 70,000 rubber seeds to Kew Gardens in London, paid by Britain's India Office. By his own later account, he told customs they were "exceedingly delicate botanical specimens". Brazil was then the world's main source of rubber. The seedlings went to British Asia, and by 1913 its plantations had overtaken the Amazon. Brazil's rubber boom collapsed. Kerala's rubber trees descend largely from the same seeds.

In Brazil, Wickham is remembered as "the father of bio-piracy": someone who profited from Brazil's plants without its consent. Wickham called it patriotism. No Brazilian law in 1876 banned taking the seeds, Brazil kept every one of its trees, and the plantations took decades of work to succeed. Britain knighted him in 1920.

2. What the Blood Was For

The Havasupai Tribe and Arizona State University · Grand Canyon, USA · 1990–2010

The Havasupai are a Native American tribe of about 650 people, living deep in the Grand Canyon. From 1990, researchers from Arizona State University (ASU) collected blood from more than 200 members. Tribal leaders were told the study was about diabetes; the written consent form spoke more broadly, of "behavioral/medical disorders".

The samples were used in 23 papers and dissertations. Fifteen had nothing to do with diabetes; they covered schizophrenia, inbreeding and the tribe's origins. One suggested its ancestors came from Asia, while the tribe's own history says they began in the canyon. Tribal council member Carletta Tilousi said: "people got degrees and grants, and they never asked our permission."

The lead researcher defended the work as ethical: science often advances through studies not tied to one disease. In 2010, ASU's governing board settled. It paid $700,000 to 41 tribe members, returned the samples and apologised, while ASU denied wrongdoing. The blood went home. The published papers did not.

3. A Search Engine for Faces

Clearview AI · New York, USA · 2017 to today

Clearview AI, an American company founded in 2017, copies publicly posted photos from social media, news sites and other websites, without telling the people in them. Its software turns each face into a faceprint, a list of numbers describing its geometry. One uploaded photo can then find other photos of the same face online. By its own count, it holds more than 100 billion images, and it sells searches mainly to police and government agencies.

Regulators in Canada, Australia and several European countries found it broke their privacy laws. Canada's privacy commissioner said: "What Clearview does is mass surveillance and it is illegal." Illinois law draws its line at the faceprint: it protects scans of face geometry, but not photographs.

Clearview's co-founder, Hoan Ton-That, said: "All the data inside Clearview AI is publicly available, as it is with Google." The company says police use it to identify suspects and abused children. It admits no wrongdoing, and has not paid several European fines.

Status as of October 2026.

Exhibit Labels and Provenance: Section 2

1. Seventy Thousand Seeds

Seed of the Pará rubber tree (Hevea brasiliensis)

Present day · Real seed

A seed of the Pará rubber tree, like the 70,000 Wickham shipped from the Amazon in 1876.

From the Tapajós to Asia (map)

1876 to the 1890s · Made for this exhibition

The seeds' route: the Tapajós river, Belém, Liverpool, Kew Gardens, then Ceylon and Malaya.

"For services in connection with the rubber plantation industry in the Far East"

1920 · Knighthood citation, London Gazette · Reproduction

Britain's verdict: the 1920 citation knighting Wickham, which does not mention Brazil.

"As sementes da discórdia" (The seeds of discord)

April 2009 · Pesquisa FAPESP, Brazil · Extract in Portuguese and English

Brazil's verdict: a Brazilian research magazine on the long debate over whether Wickham was a thief or a man of his time.

2. What the Blood Was For

Blood-collection tube

Present day · Unused demonstration object

An unused, empty tube; no Havasupai blood, image or genetic information is shown in this exhibition.

Supai, Arizona (map)

Made for this exhibition

Supai, the Havasupai village deep in the Grand Canyon, reachable only on foot, by mule or by helicopter.

From blood to ancestry (diagram)

Made for this exhibition

Blood becomes DNA, DNA becomes data, and data can answer questions no one asked when the blood was given.

What did “yes” mean? (consent panel)

1990–1994 · Based on the Arizona court record and later reviews

Three versions of one permission: what leaders were told, what the written form said, and what later donors heard.

3. A Search Engine for Faces

One face, four places (staged photographs)

2026 · Made for this exhibition with a consenting volunteer

One consenting volunteer in four settings, each photo shared with a different audience.

Face search (simulation)

Made for this exhibition · Not Clearview software

A simulation built by the exhibition team, not Clearview software: one photo finds the other three.

A face as numbers (faceprint)

Made for this exhibition

A face turned into numbers; Canada’s regulators described each Clearview faceprint as 512 data points.

Posted → collected → face data → searchable (diagram)

Made for this exhibition

The four steps that turn someone visible online into someone searchable.

Canada’s privacy commissioners

3 February 2021 · Report of findings · Extract

Canada’s 2021 finding that Clearview’s scraping was mass surveillance and broke Canadian law; Clearview disputed it.

Section 3: Who Names the Act and Who Owns the Story?

When land changes hands, the conflict begins long before the first surveyor’s peg or industrial excavator strikes the earth; it begins with language. Those in power wield bureaucratic terminology to sanitize dispossession. Communal heritage is branded "surplus," ancestral forests are classified as "mine blocks," and systemic exploitation is reframed under the banner of "development," "national progress," or "corporate stewardship."

This section sets state and corporate archives directly against the counter-archives preserved by indigenous communities. Comparing the 1887 Dawes Act in the United States with ongoing coal extraction in India’s Hasdeo Arand forest reveals identical institutional playbooks separated by over a century. Official records: statutes, clearance certificates, and glossy sustainability brochures, depict an orderly, legal redistribution of resources. In contrast, tribal petitions, forged consent controversies, and grassroots resistance tell a story of existential survival and broken treaties. By laying official claims alongside community realities, this exhibit asks: Who gets to decide what is legal, what is theft, and whose memory becomes history?

1. The Dawes Act

Allotment of Native American land · United States, 1887–1934

Before 1887, Native American tribes held and cared for their lands communally i.e. no single person "owned" a plot; the entire tribe shared it. The U.S. government passed the Dawes General Allotment Act to end this system.

The government surveyed reservations and split the shared land into small, individual private plots given to Native families. Any leftover territory was labeled "surplus" and sold off to non-Native settlers, railroads, and corporations.

Under the guise of "civilizing" tribes through private ownership, this legal sleight of hand stripped Native Americans of roughly 90 million acres which was two-thirds of their entire land base. The following exhibits trace how simple administrative labels transformed sacred communal homelands into commercial real estate, and how indigenous leaders fought to preserve their treaties.

2. The Hasdeo Arand Forest

Coal mining and forest rights · Chhattisgarh, India, 2010 to today

Spanning over 1650 square kilometres in Chhattisgarh, Hasdeo Arand is known as the "lungs of central India", a biodiversity hotspot, elephant corridor, and home to indigenous Adivasi communities whose culture and survival rely on the forest. Under Indian law, these village councils (*Gram Sabhas*) have the constitutional right to decide what happens to their ancestral land.

Beneath this ancient canopy, however, lie billions of tons of coal. Over the past decade, state agencies and corporate developers have systematically cleared vast tracts of the forest, designating them as open-cast coal blocks.

Official reports describe this extraction as essential national development and responsible stewardship. In response, local communities argue that clearances bypass their consent and destroy their watershed. The following exhibits document this unfolding clash: official environmental clearances and corporate brochures on one side, and village resolutions, forest blockades, and community defense on the other.

Exhibit Labels and Provenance: Section 3

1. The Dawes Act

“Indian Land for Sale” broadside

1911 · US Department of the Interior · Reproduction; original in the Library of Congress

A federal poster advertising 350,000 acres of allotted tribal land by sealed bid.

The Dawes Act and the allotment rolls

1887 and 1898–1914 · Reproductions; originals in the US National Archives

The statute that divided communal land into individual plots, and the rolls that decided belonging.

Cherokee memorials to Congress

About 1900 · US Congressional Serial Set · Reproductions

Petitions from Cherokee delegates protesting allotment and defending communal landholdings.

Testimony of Redbird Smith

November 1906 to January 1907 · US Senate select committee report · Reproduction

The recorded refusal of a Cherokee traditionalist leader who rejected individual allotment.

The shrinking land base, 1887–1934 (map)

Made for this exhibition

Two maps comparing Native land in 1887 with the two-thirds lost by 1934.

“SURPLUS” rubber stamp

Prop made for this exhibition

The administrative stamp that converted leftover tribal territory into public real estate.

Surveyor’s chain

Representative object

A 66-foot chain used to split ancestral territory into rectilinear, salable parcels.

2. The Hasdeo Arand Forest

Forest clearance, Parsa East and Kete Basan coal mine

March 2012 · Union Ministry of Environment and Forests · Reproduction

Official approval to clear dense forest for coal mining despite initial "no-go" classification.

Company reports

2023–2024 · Adani Enterprises ESG report and Adani Foundation CSR report · Extracts

Corporate disclosures describing the extraction zone as responsible development and tree planting.

Gram sabha resolutions

2015–2022 · Village councils of Hasdeo · Reproductions

Resolutions from local village councils refusing consent for mining under tribal forest rights laws.

Ghatbarra's forest rights: granted and cancelled

September 2013 and January 2016 · District forest rights committee · Reproductions

Community titles granted over 810 hectares of forest in 2013, then revoked for coal mining in 2016.

Protest photograph

2022 · Photographer and publication to be credited

Villagers embracing marked trees to physically prevent logging machinery from entering the forest.

Voices of the forest (audio)

2022–2024 · Field recordings · Via QR code

Field recordings contrasting ambient canopy birdsong with chainsaws and resident interviews.

Two jars

Made for this exhibition

Forest topsoil and clear water set against dark coal dust and murky water.

Felling tag: Tree #1279

Prop made for this exhibition

Timber marked with forestry serial numbers, replicating how living trees are inventoried before clearing.

Exit: Has Your Definition Changed?

At the entrance, theft seemed simple: an owner, a loss, and a law that names the act. Each section has pulled one of those apart.

In ‘Who Is the Thief?’, the act stayed the same while the label moved with the taker’s class, the story told about him, or the number of hands an object passed through. In ‘What Can Be Taken?’, the owners kept what they started with, and the dispute was over what it became. In ‘Who Names the Act?’, the law did the naming, and the people who lost land kept their own records.

None of these cases is closed. Benin objects are still being returned. Hasdeo’s forest is still being cleared and defended. Clearview’s database is still growing. The pins on the voting strips are now part of the record too: each day’s results are photographed and added to the digital catalogue.

Before leaving, visitors are invited to answer the entrance questions once more. The difference between the two answers is this exhibition’s final exhibit.

Entry and Exit Poll

The same questions are asked at the entrance and the exit, so the change in answers can be measured.

1. Can something be stolen if the owner still has it? (Yes / No / Not sure)
2. If an act was legal when it happened, can it still be theft? (Yes / No / Not sure)
3. Who should decide whether something counts as theft? (The law / The people who lost it / Society, over time / Not sure)
4. Is copying a public photo to identify someone a kind of taking? (Yes / No / Not sure)
5. Complete the sentence: “Theft is ...” (Open answer)
6. Exit only: Did any case change your answer? Which one? (Open answer)

Voting Strip Label

Theft or not?

Place one pin on the line where you think this case belongs. 0 means ‘not theft’; 10 means ‘theft’. The line is continuous because many cases here do not fit a yes-or-no answer. The first few pins were placed by the exhibition team at the opening. Each evening, the strip is photographed and added to the digital catalogue.

Visitors’ book

Museum of Theft / Visitor Reflections

Which display stayed with you, and what detail made you stop?

_____

_____

Is there a record or point of view you would like to know more about?

_____

_____

Optional name / initials: _____ Date: _____

Digital catalogue and audio guide access

Keep Following the Sources

Scan to revisit the eight displays, listen to selected audio commentaries, read transcripts and follow the historical records behind the exhibits. The catalogue distinguishes original sources from reproductions and student-made reconstructions, and offers space for the evidence that could not fit on the wall.

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